

EASTERN EUROPE

AND

THE EMPEROR NICHOLAS.

BY THE AUTHOR OF

"REVELATIONS OF RUSSIA ;" "THE WHITE SLAVE."

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CHAPTER VIII.

FINLAND AND ITS LITERATURE.

Swedish feeling in Finland—Attempt of the Russian Cabinet to neutralise it by the resuscitation of a Finnish Nationality and Literature—Famous Epic Poem of the Kalevala—Collection of the Kanletetar.

THE principality of Finland, inhabited by an aboriginal race, extends from within a few hours' sail of Stockholm up to the gates of St. Petersburg.

Its population received its laws, civilisation, and religion from the Swedes. Its higher classes are all of Swedish origin; but as complete an amalgamation has taken place as between the English population in Wales, or the French amongst the Celts of Britany.

The Swedish language is used in precisely the same manner as the English or the French in those Celtic countries. Finland was, as it is well known, lost to Sweden under the last but one of the

dynasty of Vasas, an obtuse and hasty, but well-meaning sovereign.

It was occupied by Alexander when he had been forced by Napoleon to join with him against the allies with whom he had begun the war, and lost to Sweden by the only monarch who remained faithful, in the continental struggle, to his engagements with Great Britain.

Alexander retained possession of Finland, notwithstanding his private assurance at the time that he had no intention of appropriating it.

The Finns have never ceased to regard with affectionate regret the period of their union with Sweden. In Sweden, the loss of Finland rankles so profoundly in every Swedish heart, that from Gottenburg to the borders of Lapland you cannot name the subject to the humblest peasant in the remotest hut, without seeing that the prospect of its recovery would reconcile him to any sacrifice.

Finland, from the origin of one part of its population and the predilection of the remainder, from the nature of its surface, so chequered by rocks, lakes, defiles, forests, and rivers, and peculiarly unfitted for the action of Muscovite masses, is the most favourable ground the Swedes could choose the theatre of a successful struggle.

Sweden is every day more likely to increase its power by incorporating the sister population of Denmark) with its comparative wealth and excellent sailors) in a common union.

The Danish and Swedish people, long divided by the consequences of a family feud, are identical in race and language; and their interests are the same. The prejudice which blinded them to this fact has recently been rapidly clearing away, and they are awakening to a conviction of the truth. It is to be doubted whether at the present day any political combination can eventually prevent two neighbouring people, bent on fraternising, from uniting. This Scandinavian union of Norway, Sweden, and Denmark, which the author believes first to have noticed publicly in the Revelations of Russia, and which will become imminent on the death of the present king of Denmark, is gradually occupying more attention in the north. The students of the universities go across in increased numbers to visit each other; and the consummation so much to be wished for has become a universal toast.

In Denmark, where all public demonstrations have rather reference to the destiny of that kingdom after the death of its present sovereign than to any violent changes during his lifetime, a growing spirit of liberalism manifests itself.

It is only a few weeks since that a journalist being condemned for a severe article against the absolute monarch of Prussia to a fine of near £500, on the seizure-sale of his library to defray the amount, a gentleman stepped forward and bid the amount for the first book put up for sale.

The eventual results of a Scandinavian union, must undoubtedly lead to an attempt at the recovery of Finland by Sweden; but should its accomplishment be long delayed, the feeling of the Swedes upon this subject furnishes Great Britain with the means, in the event of war with Russia, of dealing at slight cost or hazard, a serious and irrecoverable blow at that empire.

Whatever may be the political condition of Sweden, if, in event of war between Russia and Great Britain, the prospect of the recovery of Finland were held out to its people, no government could resist the popular movement, which would impel it to join with England, and invade that principality. A British fleet, and a Swedish army subsidised by England, could undoubtedly effect the conquest of this territory, in spite of every effort the Russian cabinet could make; and having occupied, permanently retain it.

Cronstadt is built on a Finnish island, and

though fortified with every care, being wholly artificial, can make no permanent resistance against the newly introduced means of destruction at the disposal of a victorious navy. The only defence of St. Petersburg, is Cronstadt; and its occupation, together with that of Finland, leave the capital itself at the invaders' mercy, and must lead to its abandonment.

War with Great Britain would, besides, at any moment rouse Poland, which is hourly drawing nearer to the renewal of a single-handed struggle with the Tsar; Turkey would at all times be eager to profit by such an eventuality; an English fleet in the Black Sea could play the same part as in the Baltic, and a small military expedition might deprive Russia of her Georgian provinces, from which she is almost cut off by the Caucasian mountaineers, and where it is four times more difficult and expensive for her to send a soldier, than it would be to Great Britain.

The author, who is prepared to enter elsewhere into military details to prove the practicability of the aggressive means to which he makes here allusion, wishes it to be understood that he is no partisan of war, which cannot in his estimation be sanctioned

on any grounds of national interest, jealousy, or aggrandisement; which even the pretence of injured national honour will not justify, and which ought never to be undertaken except in self-defence, or for the common-weal of humanity.

There are many with whom this consideration would weigh in their judgment of the conduct to be pursued by Great Britain towards the Russian despot, if it were not for the popular idea that he is as inaccessible to us as the tyrant of Bokhara. It is to assist in removing this strange misconception that the author is led to dwell on this vulnerable point which the mutual relations of Finland and Sweden offer in the panoply of that gigantic Russian despotism, to which might be so appropriately applied the epithet conferred in the whispered murmurs of the crowd, on its imperial representative when passing through Germany, of *Der Menschenfeind*, or the "enemy of humanity."

On the national feeling of the Finns of themselves, whose character the author has sketched elsewhere,—a patient, hardy race, distinguished for loyalty and fidelity,—naturally depends much of the facility which an invasion of their principality might offer. If they had been as well treated by

their new masters as by the Swedes, the course of time would have reconciled them to the change. The author has had occasion to show elsewhere how Alexander and Nicholas swore successively the maintenance of their constitution, and how both violated this oath by never allowing a representative body to assemble. This circumstance recalls too another instance of the misrepresentation prevalent in the public press, out of compliment or through fear of the Russian cabinet.

A Monsieur Leouzon le Duc, a modest and timid writer, has recently published a work on Finland, in which he gives a translation of the Kalevala, whether from the Finnish, or from the Swedish translation of Castren he does not mention. In his account of the government of Finland, he states that Alexander promised to maintain the Finnish constitution, and cites his manifest to that effect; he further mentions with apparent approbation, that Nicholas graciously confirmed it at his accession to the throne, and also gives the text of his ukase.

But he utterly omits to say that this promise was never fulfilled,—the grievance of which the Finns so bitterly complain; thus naturally leav-

ing his reader to infer that these two sovereigns had respected, instead of virtually abrogating the Finnish constitution, in the face of a pledge so solemn. Alexander otherwise pursued towards that country a system of conciliation; the exemption from duties was guaranteed for a certain number of years, and the vexatious tyranny of the bureaucracy and police restrained within tolerable bounds. The impatience of Nicholas soon began to tighten the rein. Directly after his accession, he abolished the committee for Finnish affairs, and from that moment the country was gradually Russianised, that is to say, that all the corrupt and arbitrary mechanism by which the remainder of the empire is administered, was introduced by slow degrees.

The long peace succeeding to so many years of war, the exemption from duties, and the trade with the capital, consoled the Finns for their political restrictions by an unusual increase of material prosperity. But this has been over-rated; and if we compare the progress of semi-republican Norway, a poorer country, divested of many of the same advantages as Finland, we may infer that this would have been at least the same if still united to Sweden. On the other hand, it must not be

forgotten that the exemption from heavy duties, by rendering it a vast free port, was the chief cause of its increasing wealth ; but these were only guaranteed for a certain term of years.

This term expired since the author had last occasion to advert to Finland, and as he prognosticated, the first step taken by Nicholas was to deprive it of these advantages. After taking this step, which practically taught his Finnish subjects the value of the representative forms withheld from them, it was discovered that the expense of a sufficient custom-house establishment along a coast of a thousand miles, would exceed the incomings of the customs, and the rigidity of the tariff was again relaxed. This has not been the case with the increasing severity of its administration, and aware of the danger of indisposing this population, the plan has been devised in the imperial cabinet, of resuscitating and playing off the nationality of the Finns against that of the Swedish middle-class, and of neutralizing thereby the Swedish feeling, still so obstinately prevalent in that country.

It is thus, that on the other side of the Finnish gulph, the Lettonian peasantry, and their German priesthood and nobility, are skilfully made to keep

each other in check. But there is only an apparent similitude in the two cases. In the Baltic provinces, the Teutonic knights reduced the conquered inhabitants to private servitude, and shared them out like cattle ; as in parts of Ireland, a fierce animosity lurks in the bosoms of the peasantry against this strange race of oppressors, and may be easily worked upon.

Finland, on the contrary, was equitably governed as a Swedish province,—all the recollections of her civilisation and her glories are identified in her happy association with the mother country. It is therefore as idle to attempt to detach the affections of Finland from Sweden, by reference to a nationality lost in the night of time, or to traditions connected with paganism, as it would be for the French, if in possession of Cornwall, to make its inhabitants forget their separation from England, by encouraging homely songs in their native dialect, or popularizing a poem filled with the mythologic legends of the Druids.

That the reader may be enabled to judge of the nature of Finnish national literature, a brief analysis with extracts from the *Kalevala* and *Kanteletar* is herewith given,—the one an ancient epic in two-and-thirty books, the other a collec-

tion of the lyrics of the people. The former, which is in many respects a singular and interesting production, may gratify, as a literary curiosity, at the same time that it serves to illustrate the author's argument.

The *Kalevala*—so called either from *Kawa* the father of the Finnish gods, the gigantic Saturn of its mythology, or from *Kalewala* the Finnish Olympus—is a collection of poetic myths, gathered like the songs of Homer, or as those of Ossian were once supposed to have been by Macpherson, from the oral traditions of the people, by the indefatigable Doctor Lœnnroth, and published by him a few years since. The antiquity of the whole of it is very great, as it winds up with the legend of *Mariatta* the gentle virgin, who swallows a berry, and conceiving, brings into the world a child, which usurps the empire of the god *Wainamoinen*.

It is impossible in this to mistake the Virgin Mary, and the first tradition of Christianity, dispelling the darkness of heathenism ; and therefore it is obvious that the last portions of the poem can have been composed no later than the twelfth century, when Christianity was introduced into Finland. There are allusions made in other parts of it to the invasions of Russia by the

Northmen, which occurred in the ninth century ; and some even see cause to retrace the origin of the first portions of it beyond the birth of Christ.

There is, of course, no substantial reason to be given, why these traditions, orally handed down for nine centuries as they contain incontestible proofs of having been, may not in a like manner have commenced and been transmitted from mouth to mouth nine centuries previously.

This poem of the *Kalevala*, though singularly disjointed, obscure, and confused, may be termed an epic, because all the episodes which it contains refer to the adventures of the god *Wainamoinen*, of which the thread is never entirely lost from the commencement to the termination. It is, however, an epic almost wholly mythologic, or at least human personages are only casually introduced, and chiefly in the character of sorcerers.

It is compared to the *Odyssey* by some of the learned Finns, who in their patriotic enthusiasm even give it precedence. Though it is difficult for any one but a Finn to acquiesce in this judgment, the *Kalevala* must be admitted as an interesting monument, of a distant age and of a numerous people, which probably overspread a large portion

of Europe long before it was occupied by its present races, and of which the only notable remnant is now to be found in Finland, though slender branches separated from it, and plunged in barbarism, still exist, scattered over Siberia and the north-east of Europe. This poem is also peculiar, and original, though in some passages its style is biblical, and seems to point to an oriental origin.

It is therefore not without striking beauties, and many more are probably lost to the modern reader, through the unintelligibility of the allegories and allusions with which it is filled, whilst in a translation the harmony of the versification, one of its chiefest charms, is necessarily lost upon a stranger. It is impossible to give any outline of the construction of this poem, without some slight explanation of the Finnish mythology, which is peculiar, though bearing some traces of having been derived either from that of the Greeks, or from a common source. We must however admit it to be less poetical than that of the Greeks, and less gloomily grand than that of the Scandinavians.

It mixes up the weird with the terrible, and though we have no right to condemn the most

gross apparent absurdities, which may be full of meaning lost to us, its most solemn superstitions are often chequered by images irresistibly ludicrous.

All the Finnish gods, whenever their deeds or history are recorded, appear so frequently in the character of sorcerers, that the attributes of the godhead seem inextricably confounded with the power of the magician.

They blend in a far greater degree than the gods of the Greek mythology, or of the Scandinavian Edda, the weaknesses of the man with their god-like character; rather wizards than deities, the art with which they use their spells and incantation seems chiefly to enable them to struggle with, and triumph over mortals and inferior spirits.

There is, besides, so much of contradiction and obscurity in all the Finnish myths; there appear to be so many words of which the signification is either changed or lost, that a perfectly distinct idea cannot be formed with certainty, even of the attributes of the principal deities, respecting which, the notions of the singers of the runes themselves differ perhaps as much as those of their modern commentators.

Jumala is the god of clouds and thunder; Wainamoinen of poetry and music. They represent the Jupiter and Apollo, but it is uncertain which of the two was the supreme being.

Kava the giant, the father of the gods and giants, bears some analogy to Saturn. Illmarinen the eternal blacksmith to the Vulcan of the Greeks and Romans. Tuoni is the god of death, the giant Hisii, of evil; Akto is the king of the waters; Tuopio, of the woods; Matha-Teppo, of the roads. The storm is represented by an eagle. Mehilainen is a beneficent bird, small and frail as the humming-bird, but ever bearing on its tiny wings the balm and antidote for sickness, suffering, and the spells of evil.

Besides these, the mighty sorcerers and wizards, there are numerous other gods; and every lake, stream, hill, or valley,—in fact, all animate or inanimate things have their good and evil spirits.

On this account everything is personified in their mythic poetry. The boat laments upon the shore,—the lonely tree, isolated in the clearing, mourns and complains,—the road converses with the god,—the iron in the furnace has a voice, and in its uses a volition.

But besides these passages, full of originality and

beauty, we find the witch of Pohja, whose spells can baffle the gods, sweeping up the dust upon her floor into a brazen pan. The god Wainamoinen cocks his hat gaillardly upon one side,—he laves his thumb and purifies his fingers before astonishing all nature with the harmony of his song.

The goddess of the woods draws on her blue stockings, and arrays herself in red ribbons, when irresistibly attracted to listen to the melody of the god.

Illmarinen, another divinity, in the spirit of Hudibras, seriously declares that a man is safer cased in steel, and that he prefers to go by land rather than risk himself upon the water.

It may be asked whether Nicholas or his advisers think these images calculated to efface from the minds of the Finns the recollection of the freedom they enjoyed, and the glories they achieved, when, united to the Swedes, they fought in the front ranks of the armies of the great Gustav Adolph for the civil and religious liberty of the north.

The Kalevala is divided into two-and-thirty *runes*. Like all Finnish poetry, both ancient and modern, its verse is alliterative instead of being in blank or rhymed; but from the nature of the

language, this singular kind of versification is full of harmony ; and, to judge from the facility with which it is improvised by the peasantry, must be of easy construction. For instance, the following passage from the first *rune* of the *Kalevala*, where the Lapland wizard lies in wait for the god Wainamoinen, and shoots the blue elk on which he is riding :

“ And he shot his shaft ; but it rose too high.
The sky was rent, the arches of the air were shaken.
He shot a second ; but it fell too low : it sunk
into the depths of earth—the mother of men—
down to *Manala*, whose vaults it made to tremble,”
&c.

It would be versified in the Finnish by making most of the words in one line begin with the same letter. As for instance :

Shooting a shaft it soared so high,
That it smote the sky and severed its arch ;
Then speeding a second it sunk too low,
And deeply descending down through the dark earth—
Of mortal man the mighty mother—
Made *Manalas'* murmuring vaults to quiver ;
Then, with truer aim, his third shaft he shot through
The blue bounding elk by the hero bestridden.

The first *rune* of the Kalevala opens with the birth of the god Wainamoinen, after having been thirty years imprisoned in his mother's womb. He immediately creates himself a courser—a blue and gigantic elk—on which he rides towards the seashore. But there a Lapland wizard lies in ambush for him; and discharging his fatal arrows, kills his strange steed; and the dismounted god having fallen into the sea, wanders for seven years about the waters.

FINNISH POETRY.

THE KALEVALA.

First Rune.

“A Laplander—he of the obliquely glancing eye, filled with a malignant hatred which had long rankled in his breast,—cherished dark thoughts against the venerable Wainamoinen.

“Skilled in the craft of fashioning deadly weapons,—he prepared a bow by means of fire.

“Gold, silver, iron, and steel lent to his work in turn their lustre and their power. Thus did he prepare a bow, bright to the eye, and costly in its price. Inlaid upon its back a horse bristles up

its mane ; another speeds along on that part which the arrow traverses. A bull reposes on the two wings of the bow, and a hare crouches near the notches.

“ Then he prepares a sheaf of arrows, adorning each with a triple row of feathers. He cuts them carefully, and his sons attach thereunto the light wing of the sparrow, the swallow’s tiny feathers.

“ But these shafts, who will harden them, what balsam will anoint them with its power ?

“ The black venom of the snake, the atrocious poison of the adder.

“ Wouldst thou know, too, how the feathers are attached to the shaft wherewith the bow is strung ?

“ With hairs from the mane of the hell-horse Hisii—of the stallion Lemmo.

“ The shafts are ready ; with bow in hand, and quiver resounding on his shoulders, the Laplander wends his way.

“ He reaches the cataract of the fiery torrent, the whirlpool of the sacred stream. There he watches at morn, he watches at even, he watches at mid-day. He waits the venerable Wainamoinen, the friend of the waters.

“ One day, one morn, he lifts his eyes towards the west, he turns his head towards the sun, and he sees the venerable Wainamoinen advancing toward the dark sea-waves.

“ Seizing hurriedly his bow of fire, his beautiful, his iron-bound bow, he draws from his quiver a feathered shaft, a shaft unerring and fatal, and aims at the death of Wainamoinen, at the death of the friend of the waters.

“ His mother, his wife, two sprites, and the three daughters of nature cry out together : Stay ! slay not Wainamoinen ! Waina is thine own aunt’s son !

“ But the cruel Laplander remains inflexible ; he replies : If I raise my hand, and aim too high, may the shaft fall lower ; if I lower my hand too far, may it rise higher.

“ And he shot his shaft, but it rose too high ; the sky was rent ; the arches of the air were shaken. He shot a second, but it fell too low ; if sunk into the depths of the earth, the mother of men, down to Manala, whose vaults it made to tremble. He shot a third, but this shaft pierced the blue elk through the spleen, and trans-fixed it through the left leg and shoulder.”

Wainamoinen falls into the waters from the back of his strange courser, the blue elk, and the obliquely-visioned Laplander says :—

“ Now, oh venerable Wainamoinen, as long as centuries roll on their course, as long as the moon sheds out its light, thou shalt never tread again the fields of Wainalen, the plains of Kalevala !

“ And Wainamoinen the venerable and the valiant, wandered for six winters, for seven summers, for eight years, on the plains of the waters, and the wide straits of the ocean, with the waves boiling beneath, and the sky stretching out its boundless blue above him.

“ Already the hero has numbered all the seas,— seen all the waters. Wherever he raises up his head he creates an island ; where he touches with his hand he forms a promontory ; where his feet indent the sands he digs a grave of fishes* : when he moves towards the land he enters the nets of the fishers ; when he plunges into the deep, rocks rise upon his path, and he gives birth to

* By this, no doubt, is meant one of those creeks, inlets, or deep shallows, in which the fishes are either netted or left impounded, if the expression may be allowed, by the retiring water.

shoals on which ships are wrecked, and where mariners find their graves."

Wainamoinen, in the course of his wanderings, is carried to the region of Pohjola, where the sorceress Louhi hospitably receives him, and invites him to remain.

"Times sad and sorrowful have fallen on the antique Wainamoinen. He is wafted about like the withered bough of a pine,—like the shivered trunk of a decayed tree, on the billows which he has raised, and amidst the isles which he has created,—even as the poor man is driven hither and thither by the rich, whose path he crosses."

And he mourned :

"Woe to me, unfortunate, woe to me bowed down by evil ! Alas ! what is my fate to be ; into what abyss have I fallen ! Night and day I wander ceaselessly beneath the blue vault of heaven ; pursued by the tempest, tossed by the waves in these wide straits, or on these shoreless seas.

"I know not, unfortunate that I am, in these days of sorrow, in these hours of anguish, where as my life draws to its close, I should fix my

dwelling. Shall it be in the air? shall it be in the waters? If I seek to build it in the air, where shall I lay its foundation? if I fix it in the waters, it will be swept away by the currents."

"Suddenly the south wind blows up the storm, and the waves roll in from the west; they upraise the venerable Wainamoinen, and cast him on the shore of Pohjola, the dark region where men are devoured, where heroes are swallowed up.

"And he said :

"Woe to me, unfortunate, woe to me ! borne by the waves so far from my native land, into strange and fatal regions, into unknown paths. Here all trees wound, boughs tear, and branches lacerate,—here all the evils of the world roam loose.

"What road must I follow? I know not that which leads back to my home, to my beloved land. The path on which I am leads to a forest. Onkelvoinen hath bewildered me.

"Oh, Matha-Teppo, god of pathways, come to my aid! mark out the road with posts, carve signs upon the trees, so that the lost hero may regain his way, and return in safety to the home of his country.

“Louhi, the hostess of Pohjola, the toothless crone of Pohja, had risen early.”

* * * * *

“Suddenly she pauses and gives ear, she looks afar into the plain. A plaintive wail is wafted from the sea shore.—It is not the cry of a child, nor the sorrowing voice of a woman.

“It is the cry of a beared hero, the cry of Uvontolainen (*another name for Wainamoinen*).

“Louhi the hostess of Pohjola Louhi the toothless crone of Pohja, launches her three-planked bark upon the water and rows up to Wainamoinen.”

“She finds him weeping, overcome with pain. His mouth is contracted, his beard quivers, his lips are closed, his teeth clenched.

“Louhi the hostess of Pohjola, Louhi the toothless crone of Pohja consoles the hero. She makes him sit in the bark next to the rudder, whilst she plies the oar, and makes for the entrance of Pohjola.”

“There she feeds the hero, she pours him out drink, and when he is saved from death she speaks to him and interrogates him :

“Why dost thou weep, Wainamoinen ; why dost thou complain Uvontolainen ?

“ Wainamoinen, the venerable and the valiant, replies : I am sad and weary, strange, in a strange land, unknown upon an unknown path. I weep ceaseless tears ; in sighs I consume my existence, because the waves have borne me far from my home, far from my beloved regions, towards this unknown threshold of a strange land.

“ Then Louhi said : Weep not, oh Wainamoinen ; weep not Uvontolainen ! it is meet that thou shouldst spend here thy life in this pleasant dwelling, in the midst of the daughters of Pohja, eating the meats which are offered thee, and drinking ale from the cup.

“ But the venerable Wainamoinen made answer : The food of a strange land tastes without flavour to me, even under a hospitable roof. Man is better, greater in his own country. Oh Creator ! permit me thither to return. In one's native home, water drank from the bark of the tree tastes sweeter than the ale of the stranger sparkling in the cup.

“ Well, said the hostess of Pohjola, what wilt thou give me if I lead thee back to thine own country ; back within the boundary of thine own field ; back within the walls of thine own dwelling ?”

“And the venerable Wainamoinen answered :
What wilt thou require of me, for leading me back
to the regions where I can hear the note of the
cuckoo, where I can hear the crowing of my cock,
and see the steam of my bath up-rising from my
native hearth ?”

The old crone then asks the god-hero to make for
her a *sampo*,—an article which has puzzled all the
ingenuity of the most learned commentators.
Doctor Lonnrot himself supposes it to be an image
of the god Jumala ; others variously conjecture it
to signify a magic amulet, a new Pandora’s box ;
or simply one of the hand-mills still used in
Iceland, Norway, and Finland.

Wainamoinen being unable to forge the *sampo*
himself, promises to cause it to be made by
Illmarinen. He says : “I cannot construct you a
sampo with a lid adorned with a thousand colours,
but there is in my country a worker of iron, who
forged the covering of the skies without leaving
thereon either the marks of his pincers, or the
traces of his hammer’s blows.”

Wainamoinen is on this promise allowed to
depart, when he perceives the old crone’s daughter.

“ Oh, she was beautiful, the virgin of Pohjola !
an honour to the earth, a glory to the waves !
She drew upon her legs a red tissue, and shod
her feet with precious sandals. She arrayed
herself in her most costly habits ; her neck she
encircled with a brilliant necklace, and a jewel
beams upon her bosom. All her person is radiant.
She sits upon the vault of the air, borne aloft
by the rainbow, where she shines sun-like from
afar.

“ Wainamoinen the venerable and the valiant
was hastening rapidly with a lowering brow from
the dark region of Pohjola. He raised his eyes
towards the heavens, and saw there a luminous
arc, and thereupon a beauteous virgin sitting.

“ In her hands were a golden shuttle and a
silver comb, and she was weaving a gold and
silver tissue.”

* * * * *

The god-hero, who becomes upon the spot
enamoured, entreats her to accompany him ; but
the disdainful beauty refuses, unless he will give
her proofs of his skill ; and at the third trial
Wainamoinen, having wounded himself in the
knee, can find no means to staunch the blood.
When all his enchantments fail, in the fourth

rune he seeks out the aid of a sorcerer, but the sorcerer cannot shape the requisite spell because he has forgotten the origin of iron.

“The venerable Wainamoinen made answer : I can tell thee the origin of iron ;—I know the origin of steel. Three children derive their origin from a common source,—water the elder born, fire the younger, and iron which is aged between.

“Fire displayed its fury ;—the imperious flames shot forth, spreading horror through the world. In that year of desolation, the lands were all burned up, the marshes all consumed ;—in that fearful summer which devoured with fire whose traces are indelible, all created things in nature, fire sought a refuge wherein to hide.

“Then the old man roared out from the depths of his smithy, and said :

“Where did iron hide—where did it find a refuge in that year of desolation—in that fearful summer which devoured all created things in nature?”

Wainamoinen having shown the numerous places in which the iron found refuge, amongst which he names a cloud, the summit of an oak, and lastly a marsh, in which it was found by the Finnish Vulcan, continues :—

“It was taken into the workshop of the great artisan, of Illmarinen the eternal blacksmith, who said: If I put thee into the fire—into the furnace of my forge, thou wilt become more arrogant, more great; thou wilt spread abroad terror, thou wilt kill thy brother, thou wilt shed the blood of the son of thy mother!”

Then the iron in the furnace of the forge, beneath the blows of the hammer, swore as follows:—

“I have trees to split—I have the heart of rocks to hew; no, I will not kill my brother, I will not shed the blood of my mother’s son.

“And the workman Illmarinen the eternal forger of iron, threw the iron into the hottest part of the furnace, he fashioned it when soft upon his anvil; but before he dipped it into the water to temper it, he tasted with his tongue the creative juices of the steel—the water hardening the iron, and said:

“This water is impotent to create steel, or harden iron. Oh! *Mehilainen* — friendly bird; fly hence on thy light wings! traverse all the nine seas which divide us, and half the tenth; fly over the lands, the marshes and the ocean-

straits bring back in thy bill, and on thy feathers, the honey distilled from seven blades of grass, from the petals of six flowers, that I may therewith make the steel and give the iron hardness. But the bird of Hisii (the hell-bird) took wing, and lingering round the dwelling, and beneath the eaves, watched whilst the steel was being made,—the iron hardening.

“It brought the poison of blood,—it brought the black juices of the worm, which its lizard-like eyes had seen crawling, and the hidden venom of the snake, for the steel which was being made, and for the iron which was hardening.

“Then the artisan Illmarinen, the eternal blacksmith, thought that the bird had brought the honey and the sweet juices he had asked for; and he said: This is good for the preparation of steel, for the hardening of iron.

“But ~~after~~ a moment,—a brief moment, the iron quivers with anger—it roars—it writhes; and forgetful of its oaths, devours like a dog its plighted faith. It kills its brother,—it destroys its mother’s son,—it plunges into palpitating flesh, and demeans itself so furiously that blood overflows in torrents.

“The old man roars out from the depths of his

smithy ; his beard bristles up with a rustling sound, and he shakes his head, saying :—

“ Now ! now ! I know the origin of iron, and its fatal destiny. Woe to thee, wretched iron ! woe to thee, vile Scoria ! Art thou so haughty that thou hast outraged nature and destroyed ?

“ Thou wert not so mighty,—thou wert nothing, when thou wert stagnant water,—when thou wert reposing in the mud of the boundless marsh, or on the summit of the rock.

“ Thou wert not so mighty,—thou wert nothing, when drawn from the morass, sifted from the clay of the earth, and dried from the dampness of the waters ; thou wert not so mighty,—thou wert nothing, vile Scoria, when bubbling in the furnace, or when beneath the hammer’s blows thou didst swear thy oath. Thy heart has become bad, — suffering hath corrupted thee. Wretch that thou art, thou hast violated thy oath and devoured like a dog thy plighted faith ! Who prompted thee to such a crime ? Who persuaded thee to an act so fearful ? Was it thy father, was it thy mother ? Was it the eldest of thy brothers, or the youngest of thy sisters ?

* * * * *

“ No, thou alone hast done the evil,—thou alone committed the crime of *Kalmia* !” (carnage).

Having discovered the origin of iron, a knowledge which was a necessary ingredient of his charm, the old sorcerer proceeds to stop the hemorrhage of the god-hero's wound.

He calls on Lempo to place his broad finger on the opening; "to place a door on the fearful doorway; and he says:

"Pause, oh blood! cease in thy flow,—suspend thy rapid current,—coagulate into a wall."

* * * * *

"If thou art irresistibly hurried forward, then dash on through the flesh and bones; it is more meet and fitting to flow through the flesh, to fill the swelling veins, and to bubble in the bones, than to run on the ground and be in the dust defiled.

"Thy place is in the heart,—thy seat beneath the lungs. Oh blood! without delay turn back thy current thither,—cease, oh my beloved, cease to waste abroad thy purple.

"If nevertheless thou wilt not tarry, then remember that the falls of Tyrian paused,—that the torrent *Juurtunan* staid its rushing waters,—that sea and skies were dried in the great year of desolate sterility, that year of inextinguishable fire.

“ If all this will not persuade thee, then I know another charm. I will take a vase of Hisii, the cauldron of Helvetti, in which blood is boiled, and made solid, so that it may not flow upon the earth or escape in streams.

“ Then the old man seized the extremities of the veins and counted them.”—*Fourth Rune.*

There are two things remarkable in this tradition of the origin of iron; firstly, the proof it affords, that the volcanic formations of the earth had not escaped the notice of the Finns, though most other people appear in their traditions only to have observed the Neptunian; and secondly, the progress they had made in surgery, evinced by binding up the arteries, and the conjecture of the circulating of the blood.

Wainamoinen being cured, seeks out Illmarinen, to send him to construct the *sampo*, which he has promised to the crone of Pohjola. Illmarinen refuses to venture into that dreaded region, and Wainamoinen therefore raises a whirlwind by his enchantments, which carries the eternal blacksmith thither. Illmarinen becomes enamoured too of Louhi's daughter; and works at the *sampo* day and night.

Another suitor—a mortal—the rash young

Loumikainen, however, seeks her hand, in spite of all the prayers of the witch his mother. The cruel beauty sends him to undertake labours in which he too succumbs like Wainamoinen, but he is killed, carried into the depths of the waters, and dismembered by the children of *Tuoni*.

His sorrowing mother seeks him out, she asks tidings of him of the mountain path, of the sun and of the moon. They answer her ; and through their directions she gathers up his limbs, and by the help of the beneficent bird Mehilainen infuses into them fresh life.

Meanwhile Wainamoinen is wending his way towards Pohjola, to seek the hand of the daughter of Louhi ; but he has forgotten the three magic words which can lead him thither, and he wanders vainly about seas and different regions. At length he bethinks him that they are known to the giant Wipunen, but the giant Wipunen has been long dead and buried. His bones are rock, his mouth and entrails a cave, his beard a forest. He will not answer till Wainamoinen enters into his body and tortures him, and then gives up his secret.

Wainamoinen, by means of the spell he has acquired, reaches Pohjola ; but the daughter of

Louhi prefers Illmarinen to his brother, and gives him her hand.

Loumikainen, the third suitor, whom the skill of his mother has recovered from death, arrives too late, and is detained at his return on an enchanted island.

Illmarinen returns with his bride, and buys a slave, Kullervo, who when three days old had rent his swaddling clothes, and climbed upon the house-top. Kullervo is sent by the wife of Illmarinen into the woods and fields to tend the flocks; she makes him a loaf, the upper part is of wheaten flour, the under of barley, but in the middle there is a stone. The slave, to revenge himself, instead of driving home the cattle, calls the bears, the wolves, and the lynxes, who devour his mistress.

The widower Illmarinen laments his loss, and to console himself forges a wife of gold and silver; but he cannot confer upon her the gift of speech, and when he takes her to his couch she imparts to his bosom a death-like chillness.

The stone in the bread of the slave, and the cheerless frigidity of the gold and silver spouse which the Finnish Vulcan makes to himself, are both full of significance as allegorical of the

danger of harshness and cruelty towards dependents, and of the discomforts of an interested union.

Illmarinen and Wainamoinen, learning the happiness which the *sampo* they have made for Louhi confers upon the region of Pohjola, determine to carry it off.

“The workman *Illmarinen* then puts on his armour. He dons a hauberk of iron, and girdles himself round with an iron belt. He says: Man is better in a cuirass, mightier in an iron tunic, more powerful in a belt of steel.”

* * * * *

“As they follow the road through the solitary forest, they hear the moans of a vessel,—of a bark lamenting.”

“*Wainamoinen* the venerable and the valiant, said: I hear a vessel’s moans, I hear a bark lamenting. Shall we use that bark to cross the waters, or shall we traverse on our steeds the sea-shore’s sand? And the artisan *Illmarinen* replied: The route by land is most safe. The sea is the sojourn of death, there may the tempest overtake, the gush of the winds overturn us, and our

fingers may be changed to oars, our hands to rudders.

“And the venerable *Wainamoinen* made answer: Though the land route may be more safe, it is longer and more tedious. Joy tenants the bark when it careers on the wild waves, when it breasts the open seas, or tempts the dangers of the narrow straits. The light wind wafts it, the zephyr plays with it, and it is urged onwards by the blast of mid-day.

“He threw his reins from him and drew near unto the bark, to the bark that was lamenting.

“And he said: Why dost thou mourn, oh bark of wood? Is it because thou art too heavy,—because thou art ill-constructed?

“And the wooden bark replied: The bark sighs for the wave as the bride sighs for the house of the bridegroom. I do not mourn because too heavily fashioned, or because ill-constructed, but I mourn because when men built me it was promised me that I should roam a gallant war-boat, that I should be led to distant combats, and brought back laden with rich spoil.

“But I have never been led to combat; I have never yet been launched upon the seas; and yet other barks, worse constructed, are being led con-

stantly to battle, and return laden with more corn than a king gathers in six harvests ; with more gold than the blacksmith earns in seven summers. And here am I the boat of Wainamoinen, left alone to rot and perish on the spot where I was built. The gnawing earth-worm eats into my timbers, and every foul bird of the air within me builds its nest.

“ Ah ! it would have been a fate far better—a thousand times better for me if I had been left still a pine upon the hill, or a birch-tree in the valley, with the squirrel disporting in my branches, or the birds fluttering joyfully amidst my leaves.”

They embark in the boat, and steer towards Pohjola. On their way thither they meet Louimainen, who joins in this expedition.

Their boat is suddenly stopped ; they discover that they are aground on the back of an enormous fish.

“ Wainamoinen having severed in twain the monstrous pike, on which his boat was stranded, says :

“ What could be made of the teeth of this mighty fish, if given to a cunning artificer ?

Illmarinen asks :—

“ What could be made out of such a worthless thing, even by a skilful workman ? ”

The venerable Wainamoinen replies : “ A skilful artificer would therewith construct a chantal ” (musical instrument.)

But no artificer was found skilful enough to make the chantal.

“ Then the venerable Wainamoinen set to work himself. Whence hath he drawn the stuff whereof to make the sonorous body of the instrument ? From the forest filled with the wild plum-tree, and with the resounding timber of the pine. Whereof hath he made the pegs of the chantal ? From the teeth of the monstrous pike—of the fish which is already the slave of *Tuoni* (death.) Little is now wanting to complete the chantal. A nerve and a couple of silken strings. Wherewith will Wainamoinen contrive these chords ? With hairs from the mane of the hell-horse ; from the hide of Lemmo’s stallion.

“ The instrument is complete ; the chantal is ready.

“ Wainamoinen the valiant and the venerable now orders the old men to sing. They sing, but

their heads shake with a palsied motion ; joy is not re-echoed by joy ; the song is not re-echoed by the song.

“ Wainamoinen the valiant and the venerable orders the young men to sing. They sing, but their cramped fingers draw from the instrument inharmonious tones ; and mournful sound the joyous accents of the song.

* * * * *

“ Then Wainamoinen the venerable and the valiant laves his thumbs and purifies his fingers ; he sits him down by the sea-side, upon the stone of joy, upon the silvery hill, on the summit of the golden mountain, and taking up the instrument, he says : Let those who have never known the joy of the *runes*, nor the melody of the instrument, let them draw near and listen.

“ And the old Wainamoinen begins to sing ; his voice rises clear and liquid, his fingers play lightly over the strings of the chanted ; joy answers joy ; the song responds unto the song.

“ There is no beast in the forest, no living thing in the air, which does not hasten up at the singer of runes, to listen to his melodious voice, to revel in the harmony of his song.

“ The wolf quits the sedges in which he was prowling, the bear emerges from his den in the

roots of an overturned pine-tree, they climb a hedge,—the hedge is borne down and broken by their weight; the one ascends the trunk of a pine, the other climbs a birch-tree, whilst Wainamoinen sings and gives birth to joy.

“The black-bearded old man, the noble king of the forest, all the host of *Tapio* hasten up to listen. The very hostess of the woods herself, the fearless woman of *Tapiola*, dons her blue hose, arrays herself in red ribbons, ascends into the trunk of a hollow birch, lending a wondering ear to the god’s song.

“There is no beast of the forest—no bird of the air, which does not hasten to hear the marvellous art of the musician, the melody of the singer.

“The eagle descends from the clouds, the falcon swoops down through the air, the sea-gull wings its way from the sullen marsh, the swan from the bosom of the limpid waters; the lively linnet, the swift-winged lark, and the merry gold-finch, come to perch upon the shoulders of the god-hero.

“The beauteous virgins of the air, the sun dazzling in splendour, and the soft-rayed moon, have alike paused to listen at the further end of

a long light cloud, in the luminous vault of heaven. There they were weaving the wonderful texture of the skies, with a golden shuttle and a silver comb, when astonished by the strange voice and the melodious accents of the hero's song.

"The comb of silver fell from their hands, the golden shuttle breaking the threads of the woof, escaped from their fingers. All the living things of the waters, all the fishes waving at once their myriad fins, swam up to hear the voice of Wainamoinen, to listen to the harmony of his song.

"The salmon and the trout, the pike and the seal, the large fishes and the small, draw as near as possible to the voice of the charmer.

"Ahto, the king of the waves, the old man with the green beard of weeds, rises up on a water-lily to the surface of the deep.

"The fruitful hostess of the seas was combing her long hair with a comb of gold. She hears the song of *Suomi*, and the comb falls from her hands; wondering and agitated, she can remain no longer in the deep, but makes for shore; there with her breast against a rock she listens, panting, to the sounds of Wainamoinen's chantal, wherewith the hero's voice mingles its melody. She listens because the sounds were so sweet, the voice so full of harmony.

“ There is neither woman nor hero, nor man
so hardened, as to hear them without tears.

* * * * *

“ Old Wainamoinen himself felt the well of
his tears overflowing. They soon fell from his
eyes more numerous than the berries on the hill.

* * * * *

They fell from his cheeks on to his breast,
from his breast to his knees, from his knees on to
his feet, and from his feet they rolled in the dust.

* * * * *

“ The tears of Wainamoinen flow in a stream
to the sea-shore, from the sea-shore into the
depths of the ocean, where they sink in its dark
sands.

“ There flowering, they were changed to pearls,
the pearls which adorn the diadems of kings, and
become the delight of warriors.

“ Whereupon the venerable Wainamoinen said :
Is there amongst these youths, or these daughters
of illustrious lineage, any one who will dive into
the deep sea, into the region of its dark sands, to
gather as they fall those tears of mine ?

“ But young and old made answer : There is
none amongst us who dare dive into the dark deep
sea, in the region of its dark sands, to gather up
thy tears.

“Then, a sea-mew with blue-tinted plumage dipped its bill in the cold waters, gathering the pearls into which Wainamoinen’s tears had grown, from the deep sea, in the region of the dark sand.”—*Twenty-second Rune*.

It is impossible not to be struck with the close resemblance of this legend, to the myth of the Greek Orpheus.

These new Argonauts seize the sampo, and bear it off in their boat; but the sorceress Louhi appeals to Ukko, the god of the waters, who raises a tremendous tempest, in the midst of which she pursues them. Wainamoinen hurls at her a rock, which splits her bark. She then changes into an eagle, and seizes on the *sampo* with her talons. Wainamoinen lays about him with an oar, and crushes all her claws, excepting one, in which she bears off the lid of that mysterious article yeleft the *sampo*. The remainder falls into the water. The sorceress then buries the sun and the moon in the side of a mountain. In vain Illmarinen forges one of gold and another of silver, they give no light. At length he makes an iron collar for the crone; and then, alarmed, he replaces them in the heavens.

“Oh fair moon!” says Wainamoinen, “thou art now delivered from the bondage of the rock. Resplendent sun, thou art arisen from the inside of the mountain!”

* * * * * *

“Thus rise each day, giving fertility to our fields, good fortune to our nets, and success to our hunters. Go onward in thy glory! Proceed in thy bright career, describe thy spendid arc, and when the night approaches set gloriously!”—
Twenty-seventh Rune.

The struggle between good and evil, the gods and the magicians, is over.

Wainamoinen returning from a vain search after his lost chantal, pauses before a burned forest.

“There he looks round him, he listens, and he hears the birch-tree mourning and lamenting. And he said, Why dost thou weep, why dost thou complain, oh tree of the green foliage, tree belted with white bark! Is it because thou art not led to battle?”

“The birch tree replies with wisdom: There are many who laud my happiness, who speak only of my joys. Alas! unfortunate that I am,

I rejoice even in my sufferings and my sorrow ; it is only when pain grows unendurable that I complain.

“ Oh, now I deplore my unhappy fate, for I find myself without support or help on this accursed spot, in this unsheltered clearing. Cruel and pitiful is my fate. The shepherds tear me in the summer, they cut through my white robes, and drain out all my sap.”

The songster here makes allusion to the custom prevalent throughout the north, of making in the spring an incision in the bark of the birch-tree, and extracting from it the sweet juices, then abounding, which when fermented constitute the native wine of these hyperborean regions.

“ Often too,” continues the birch-tree, “ in this accursed spot, in this burned field, I am deprived of my small boughs, and cut up piecemeal.

“ Thrice during this summer, beneath the shade of my branches, men have sat sharpening their axes and conspiring against my head.

“ This is why I spend my life in weeping and lamenting, for I am helpless, I am unprotected against the tempest, against the storms of winter.

“Each year grief changes me before my time. My head is bowed down with care, my bark grows white when I think on the frost, and on the accursed times. The storm brings me suffering, the cold brings fatal days. The tempest tears my flanks, strips me of all my leaves, and leaves me thus nakedly exposed to all its rigour.”

“Then the venerable Wainamoinen said : Oh green birch tree, weep not, for I will change thy mourning into joy, thy days of sorrow into days of happiness.

“And the venerable Wainamoinen cut the branches of the birch, and of their wood he made him a new chantal.”

* * * * *

He is seeking chords for his instrument.

“A young virgin was weeping in a burned forest, she was the most beautiful girl in the whole vale. She was not overwhelmed with grief, but only oppressed with melancholy, and she sang to beguile the weariness of the hour whilst waiting for a suitor.

“The venerable Wainamoinen saw the tears of the gentle girl, and he said : Oh virgin, make me a gift, give me five of thy beauteous hairs, give me six of them, so that I may therewith make sweet strings for my chantal.

“ And the virgin gave him five of her beauteous hairs, and she gave him six ; and Wainamoinen made with them sweet strings for his chantal.”

* * * * *

The Finnish Orpheus sings to his new instrument :

“ And when he went out into the woods the pines bowed towards him, the firs saluted him, and the birch-trees inclined their summits to the earth. When he walked out into the fields, where all was charred with fire, the flowers sprang up, and the grass grew green beneath his footsteps.”—*Twenty-ninth Rune.*

Wainamoinen becomes enamoured of the virgin ; but her brother, the young Joukahainen, defies him ; he struggles with him in enchantments, and succumbs to the power of the god-hero. In his agony he offers him his bow, his courser, and at length his sister, which the god accepts.

“ The sister of the young Joukahainen went into the woods to cut some branches and to gather leaves.”

* * * * *

“ Then the venerable Wainamoinen said to her :
Grow up, bearing me, and not other men, in thy
thoughts. Grow in thy gorgeous vestments, in thy
tunics of fine wool, and eat of bread kneaded from
the purest wheat.

“ The virgin hied her home, sobbing and weep-
ing. Her father said to her : Why weepest thou,
my child ? why art thou sorrowful, my gentle
daughter ?

“ And she replied : I weep, oh my father, because
I have lost the silver *cross* suspended from my neck,
and the buckle of gold which bound my girdle.”

* * * * *

“ And her mother said to her : Why weepest
thou, my poor child ?

“ Oh, my mother ! I have cause to weep ; I
went into the forest to cut branches and to gather
leaves. Suddenly *Osmonen* rose from the valley,
Kalevainen from the bottom of the marsh. Young
girl, said he, grow up, bearing me and no other
men in thy thoughts.

* * * * *

“ After three nights her mother came for her, and
said : Why weepest thou, my child ? why dost
thou mourn, my daughter ?

“ I weep, oh my mother, because I do not

wish to marry Wainamoinen. I do not wish to become the stay of a decrepid old man,—the companion of his heart. Oh! I would sooner plunge into the deep waters and become the sister of the otter, or of the fishes. It is sweet to dive into the sea, to inhabit under the wave, to live as the sister of the otter, and of the fishes.

“ And the young girl entered her wardrobe, and she opened her richest presses, and arrayed herself in the most gorgeous attire, and then she plunged into the deep waters to become the sister of the otter, and of the fishes.

“ Three nights after her mother came into her chamber : Oh ! where is my daughter ? My poor child is dead ! She has gone into the deep waters to become the sister of the fishes and of the otter, and the otter and the fishes are now devouring their sister.”—*Thirty-first Rune.*

* * * * *

The last rune introduces Mariatta.

“ The beautiful child who grew apace in her lofty hall. The door-frame delighted in the contact of her soft vestments, and of the long ringlets of her silky hair ; whilst the ground felt flattered by the tread of her light feet.

* * * * *

“ On the hill a little berry hung suspended to a bough,—a small red berry :

“ Come, oh gentle virgin, it said, and pluck me ; oh young girl bedecked with a tin buckle, come before the worm hath destroyed, or the snake defiled me.

“ She plucks off the berry, which rises from the ground to her waist, from her waist to her bosom, from her bosom to her lips, and thence it is taken into her breast. She conceives, and brings it into the world a child.

“ She laid it in a manger on the hay, dried in the summer’s sun.”

* * * * *

Such were evidently the first confused traditions of Christianity, which penetrated amongst the pagan Suomi.

“ The venerable Wainamoinen, the eternal singer of runes, approached and said :

“ Take out the child into a marsh, crush its head, and bruise its limbs with a sledge hammer.

“ But the child a fortnight old, said to him : Old man who comest from so far,—rune-singer of Karjala, thou hast pronounced rash judgment, and hast unjustly interpreted the law.

“And the priest christened the child, and crowned it king of the forest, and gave it the custody of the isle of treasures.

“Then the antique Wainamoinen reddening with shame and anger, sang the last song; he built himself a boat of bronze,—a bark with a keel of iron; on this bark he steered away into etherial space, up to the regions of the lower heavens.

“There his boat anchored,—there his voyage ceased. But he has left upon the earth his chanted, and his mighty runes, to the eternal delight of Finland.”

So, after these confused allusions to the Virgin Mary, the infant Jesus, the manger in the stable of Bethlem,—the visit of the wise men, and the persecution of Herod, the *Kalevala* concludes, typifying the disappearance of the old gods of its mythology before the new light which had arisen.

The Kanteletar, so called from the instrument denominated chanted, is a collection of fugitive pieces, composed long since the introduction of Christianity, down to the present day, by the Finnish peasantry, and gathered during five years

of exertion, by Doctor Lænnrot, the editor of the Kalevala.

Every event of the peasant's life, his joys, his hopes, his sorrows, his fears, his rural occupations, and the pastoral scenes in which his existence passes are all chronicled in these disjointed fragments, which, imbued with a profound tinge of melancholy, are more remarkable for harmony and fluency, than for originality or depth of thought.

The following may be taken as a fair specimen.

THE LAMENT OF THE BRIDE.

“When I return from the fountain, I hear the song of two birds. If I were a bird, if I could sing, I would sing on every bough, and give life to every bush.

“Above all I would sing when the poor or sorrowing passed me, and I would be silent when the happy and the rich went by.

“How is grief to be known? Oh, grief may easily be told! Those who suffer timidly complain, whilst the happy are triumphant.

“What was thought and said of me, when I chose a bridegroom out of my native land, and turned my back upon my home?

“ Now I am in a strange land, and on an unknown spot.

“ Better is a little water in one’s own country than ale drank from a silver vessel in the land of the stranger.

“ If, as so many others have, I had only a horse to harness in a sledge, the trappings and the reins, I would take the reins lightly in my hand, and I would speed,—speed without tarrying, till I saw the the fields of Savolax, and the smoke uprising from my father’s roof.”

THE LOVERS.

“ Wilt thou come with me, oh my beloved ?
Wilt thou come and be happy with me ?

“ What happiness canst thou offer me ; thy hands are empty, thy pockets are empty ?

“ But, with these empty hands I can bear thee off into the forest shade, into the silent plains, far from the world and its envious eye, and there watch tenderly over thee.

“ But, whither shall we go, and whither wilt thou build our dwelling ?

“ There is still room enough in our own Finland. Wilt thou come with me into the uninhabited fields ? Wilt thou follow me into the

forest like a joyous bird? There I will raise thee up a dwelling, where the wind shall rock thee, and where I will delight thee with my song. I will build thee a bower of fruit-trees, a bed of ash, and my song shall nurse thee to a slumber of sweet dreams."

No doubt innumerable volumes of such poems as abound in the *Kanteletar*, might be collected in Finland; for whatever ideas we may form of the south, as the fitting home of the muses, it is worthy of remark, that two of the northernmost countries of Europe are distinguished beyond all others in the world by the passionate devotion of their inhabitants to some of the pursuits of these divinities.

No people in Europe are so fond of dancing as the Norwegians, or of song as the Finns. Every hamlet in Finland has its one, or many poets, who improvise on every incident; writing their effusions down when they can write, and transmitting them orally when unacquainted with the use of letters.

It may, however, be doubted, whether this universal passion for improvisation, and the facility for succeeding in it, afford any great promise of poetic talent. Amongst the lower

order of Spaniards and Italians, who possess it in a less degree than the Finns, it appears, as with the Finns, rather a result of the love of song, that is to say of the harmony of unmeaning words, than of any poetic gift.

We are often struck with surprise at the utter want of sense, coherence, or elevation of sentiment, expressed in the songs of these natural improvisators, which, if conveyed in sounds that strike the ear, are treasured up by them.

Few that have travelled in the south of Europe, have not been woefully disappointed with the common-place vulgarity of the thoughts expressed by these spontaneous songsters, or can fail to have been struck with the indifference and obtuseness to anything but sound, of the populations amongst whom they abound. These people, in fact, are rather musicians than poets; and though music is classed as a sister art with poetry, ought we not to consider it as a very childish sister?

Is it not the lowest expression of human mind, since it may be only indicative of a sensation, not of an idea; like the sounds which animals emit, however harmoniously, as in the nightingale?

The national fondness of the Finnish nation for versification, to which it is farther tempted

by the exceeding harmony and softness of its language, affords, therefore, no reason why we should expect any remarkable beauty or sublimity in its compositions.

The higher, middle, and learned classes amongst the Finns, the clergy, and the inhabitants of the coast, are of Swedish name, origin, and aspect; they write and speak in that language. In all other respects, thoroughly identified with the population, they occupy in that country the same position as the English race in Wales.

These classes have indeed furnished two distinguished poets, Franzen and Runeberg, who have written in Swedish, besides several of minor merit.